



RAVI S SAHNI



HANDOVER: Akali supremo Badal (left) has shrewdly buttressed his son's position as the heir

IN THE ABSENCE OF INSTITUTIONAL POWER VESTED WITH HIM, HIS EFFORTS TO PUSH PROJECTS ARE INVITING CRITICISM. HE IS ALREADY BEING LABELLED A "DREAM MERCHANT".

"Where are the resources for all the projects he is bragging about day in and day out," asks Amarinder, adding, "His model of development is nothing but empty announcements". The fact is Sukhbir's model is not dependent on the state budget and draws on public-private partnerships. But his initiative to sell prime government land to raise equity has led to a controversy with the Opposition likening it to selling the family silver. Already, government properties worth Rs 1,000 crore have gone under the hammer, while more are on the block. But he justifies the sale calling it "strategic asset management".

He has extended his corporate style to the party, by setting up a state-of-the-art head office at Chandigarh costing Rs 2 crore. His next plan is to set up 'wired' party offices in districts. His biggest asset—and perhaps his weakness as well—is that in sharp contrast to his father's spartan and earthy moorings, he revels in making power statement in his lifestyle and politics. In fact, he has radically transformed the traditional party's complexion by injecting his modern management philosophy and bringing about a generational shift as part of his strategy to stuff his own loyalists in the rank and file in the name

of giving the party a "young profile". On the face of it, he has mastered the art of juggling his contrasting role in politics and personal life. In his political avatar, he is at ease with the rough and tumble of grassroots politics. In private life, he exudes the air of a hi-flying corporate honcho. Fond of Chinese food, the diet Coke-sipping Sukhbir travels in two bullet-proof luxury Pajeros with identical number plates (CH03 Y 3708). He is passionate about rearing thoroughbred horses at his stable in his ancestral village Badal in Faridkot district, and his latest acquisition is an expensive dwarf breed he imported from Dubai. Apart from hotels and resorts, he runs a transport business also.

But in the absence of institutional powers vested with him, his efforts to push projects are inviting criticism. He is already being labelled a "super chief minister". Worse, he has shown no inclination to roll back the fund-guzzling freebies, like free power to farmers that have seriously bled the state exchequer and crippled government investments where it is most needed, in the health and education sectors. Clearly, the jet-set jathedar has a lot to prove before he eventually lands the top job. ■